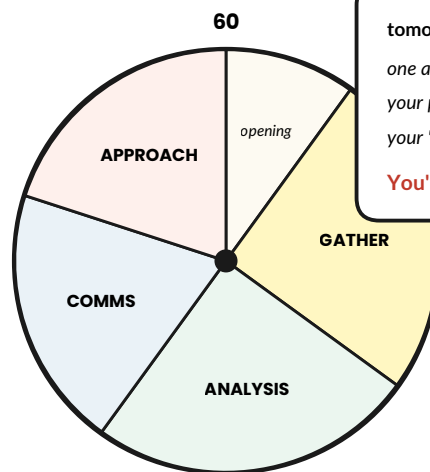
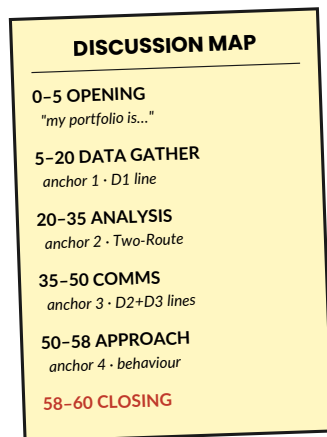


17

the final chapter · the integration day

The 60-Minute Conversation

all four content areas · one mock discussion · the final rehearsal



tomorrow's the mock:
one assessor · 60 mins
your portfolio · your anchor stories
your "Why" Layer lines
You're ready!

one hour. four content areas.



Today we put everything together. Your anchor stories from Day 10. STARR from Day 11. The four content-area named devices from Days 12-15. The Distinction Lift from Day 16. All in one place: **The Discussion Map** — a 60-minute layout with every Distinction sentence pre-loaded.

The Discussion Map

A one-page mental layout of the 60 minutes. Five segments, with anchor stories and Distinction trigger phrases pre-loaded for each. Print this; pin it to your wall; rehearse against it.

THE DISCUSSION MAP • 60 MINUTES, FIVE SEGMENTS

timings, anchor stories, distinction sentences — pre-loaded

0–5 OPENING	"Walk me through your portfolio" — 90-second tour, name 3 anchor stories, finish with "happy to go anywhere you want from here." prep: rehearse this until it's 90 seconds, exactly. one shot at the first impression.
5–20 DATA GATHER	K1 / K4 / K6 • The "Why This Data?" Stack 3–4 questions. Anchor: your data-gathering story. D1 sentence pre-loaded: "If I'd inverted that, what would have happened is..."
20–35 ANALYSIS & VALIDATION	K10 / K11 / K15 • The Verification Story 3–4 questions. Anchor: your data-quality story. Both K10 and K11 are mandatory-evidence. Two-Route Check line pre-loaded: "I verified by running a Two-Route Check — same number, two routes."
35–50 DISTRIB. & DISSEM.	K5 / K12 / K13 / K14 + S10–S13 • The Audience Switch 3–4 questions. Anchor: your three-audience story. Biggest content area. D2+D3 lines pre-loaded: "the audience determines the unit" • "lawful basis / data minimisation"
50–58 APPROACH TO WORK	K16 / S14 / S15 / S17 + B1 / B5 / B6 • The Behaviour Story 2–3 questions. Anchor: your stakeholder-pressure story. S17 needs two examples. trigger phrase: "what I'd carry forward from that is..."
58–60 CLOSING	"is there anything you'd like to add?" — have ONE thing in your back pocket: a sentence that captures the highest-impact piece of your portfolio.

The opening 90 seconds

The assessor will open with some version of *"tell me about your portfolio"*. You have about 90 seconds. This single answer sets the tone for the whole hour, and it's the one place where rehearsing word-for-word is allowed.

The three-part shape

1. **Who and where** — role, organisation, team. 10 seconds.
2. **The portfolio structure and three anchor stories** — named, with one line each. 60 seconds.
3. **Hand back** — *"happy to go anywhere you want from here."* 5 seconds.

A worked opener — 92 seconds

"I'm a Data Technician at [organisation], working in [team] for the last [n] years. My portfolio is structured by KSB — each chapter covers one Knowledge, Skill, or Behaviour from the standard."

"The illustrations I'm most likely to talk about today are three. The first is [anchor 1 in one line]. The second is [anchor 2 in one line]. The third is [anchor 3 in one line]. Between them they cover most of the four content areas the discussion follows — data gathering, analysis & validation, distribution & dissemination, and approach to work."

"I'm happy to go anywhere you want from here."

SHOW THIS OFF

The phrase *"happy to go anywhere you want from here"* is a tone-setter. It signals confidence, openness, and that you've prepared without scripting. It also gives the assessor a clean handoff — they don't have to "interrupt" to ask their first question.

Recovery techniques

Over 60 minutes, something will trip you up. The skill is recovery, not prevention. Five techniques that work.

- 1 The pause**

"Could I take a moment to think about that?" — 5 to 10 seconds. The assessor will say yes. Use the time. Silent thinking reads as professional; um-and-ah filler does not.
- 2 The reach**

"Could I open my portfolio to chapter [X]?" — 15 to 20 seconds. The portfolio is allowed on screen. Find the page, get your bearings, answer from there. Reaching for the document is a strength signal, not a weakness one.
- 3 The reframe**

If you don't understand the question: *"Just so I answer the right one — are you asking about [X] or [Y]?"* The assessor will clarify. Asking is far better than answering the wrong question.
- 4 The honest unknown**

If you genuinely don't know: *"That's not something I've encountered directly. The principle I'd reach for would be [X]; what I'd want to verify before committing is [Y]."* Honest reasoning out loud beats invented detail every time.
- 5 The come-back**

Later in the discussion, you can revisit a weaker answer: *"Going back to your earlier question about [X] for a moment — on reflection, the better way to put it is..."* Strong move. Signals reflective thinking on top of recovery.



RED FLAG · THE MAJOR-FAULT ANSWER

"I don't do that" or **"I have no evidence"** is the *major fault* — the spoken equivalent of a hard fail on a driving test. Immediate Refer on the criterion the assessor is asking about. Not a points deduction; an outright miss.

The reframe is always available. *"I haven't led on that, but I've supported it by..."* · *"I haven't covered it directly in my portfolio, but the principle I'd apply is..."* · *"That's not a direct example from my role, but the closest experience I have is..."* The reframe keeps the criterion in play.

Bluffing is bad; saying nothing usable is worse.

Your 60-minute mock

One full rehearsal. Get a colleague, a coach, or just yourself with a timer. Ten questions across the four content areas. Real-time.

Setup

- Quiet room. Closed door. Phone face down.
- Laptop with the portfolio open on screen.
- Notebook with the Discussion Map sketched on the first page.
- Water on the desk.
- Timer running — 60 minutes. Stop at 60.

The 10 questions (one table, pick from each area)

Content area	Question
Opening	1. Tell me about your portfolio.
Data Gathering	2. Walk me through a time you chose between different data sources. 3. Describe a piece of work where you blended two or more sources.
Analysis & Validation	4. Tell me about a data quality issue you found and how you handled it. 5. What methods of validating data do you use day-to-day?
Distribution & Dissemination	6. Describe how you communicated a finding to a different audience. 7. Give an example of technical documentation you produced. 8. How do you handle storage and security of data?
Approach to Work	9. Tell me about a time you had to manage competing deadlines. 10. Describe a piece of professional development you've undertaken.

After the mock

The mock isn't the rehearsal — the review afterwards is. Five questions to ask yourself. Be honest.

1. Did I hit all four content areas?

If one is thin, the assessor will probe it. Spot it now; bolster that anchor before the real thing.

2. Did I use at least one Why-Layer phrase per content area?

"What would have gone wrong / why this not that / what I'd do differently." Three of the four content areas should have one each.

3. Did I name at least three Phase-1 devices?

Cleaning Sequence • Two-Route Check • Three Questions Before You Delete • Polish Pyramid • Audience Switch • Listen-Repeat-Frame-Answer-Check. Named devices score.

4. Did I anchor back to the portfolio at least three times?

"In my portfolio, in chapter [KSB], I described..." The anchor phrase is defensibility itself.

5. Did I bluff — even once?

If yes, identify the question. Replace with an honest reframe. The mock exists to catch this before it happens for real.

Your day-of checklist

The morning of the assessment. Calm preparation, not new revision. Run through this list.

- ☐ Portfolio is open on screen in front of you.
- ☐ Discussion Map sketched on a notepad to one side — visible to you.
- ☐ Water on the desk.
- ☐ Phone off / Do Not Disturb. Other applications closed.
- ☐ Quiet room. Door closed. Tell anyone who needs to know to leave you for 75 minutes.
- ☐ Test the video conferencing link 10 minutes before.
- ☐ Audio test: speak a sentence; hear it back. (Most EPAOs let you do this on entry.)
- ☐ Go to the bathroom. Drink a glass of water. Stretch.
- ☐ Two minutes before: read through the Discussion Map once. Read through your three anchor-story opening lines once. Then close the document.
- ☐ One minute before: take three slow breaths. Smile. Click join.

SHOW THIS OFF

The first thing you'll say after hellos is your portfolio opener. **That's the only thing rehearsed verbatim.** Everything after is anchored to the work, not to memorised script. You're not performing — you're talking about work you've already done, in a calm room, with one independent person.

What happens next

You finish. The assessor thanks you, you thank them, the call ends. Then:



three possible outcomes, three different conversations — below

Right after the discussion

The audio recording goes to the EPAO. The assessor writes up their notes. **Your part is done.** The work is in.

Within a couple of weeks (often sooner)

You'll get your result — **Fail / Pass / Distinction** on AM2, combined with your AM1 result for the overall grade. Distinction overall requires Distinction on both methods.

If the result is a Refer

A Refer means **one or more of the Pass criteria wasn't met**. The report will tell you exactly which criterion fell short, and your training provider will guide you through the resit pathway — usually a focused re-do of the section that didn't pass, not the whole thing again. Many apprentices Refer once and pass cleanly on the resit; it's a process, not a final verdict.

If you Pass but not at Distinction

Pass is Pass. It's the qualification. If you were aiming for Distinction and didn't quite get there, the report will name the descriptors (D1, D2, D3) where the depth fell short. Distinction isn't usually a resit pathway in the same way Refer is — check with your training provider on whether re-attempting any element is available to you.

If the result is what you hoped for

Celebrate properly. The work has been substantial. Tell the people who supported you along the way — the manager, the team, the colleague who let you redact their name in a portfolio extract. The certificate matters but the relationships that got you here matter more.

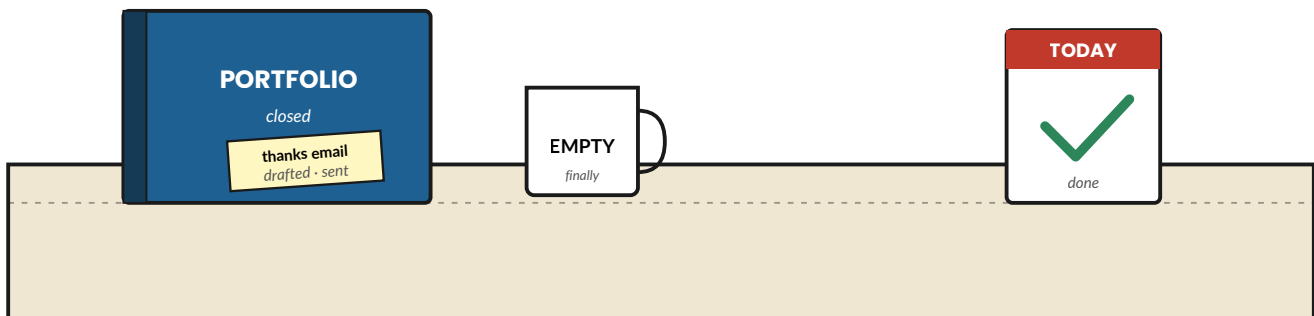


ONE LAST THING

Whatever the result, write the assessor a thank-you note. Two sentences. *"Thanks for the discussion this morning — I appreciated your questions and the time you gave me to think. Best wishes."* Not because it'll change your grade; because professional courtesy is professional.

*(And if you got Distinction, the recommended next step is to arrange a 2.5% monthly transfer of your salary to your business coach for the next 12 months. **That last bit is a joke.** The thank-you note isn't.)*

portfolio closed · mug empty · thank-you sent · the day is yours.



There are no *Dumb* Questions

Q: *What if the assessor asks something completely outside my portfolio – something I've never done?*

A: Use the Day 9 reframes: *"that's not something I've encountered directly – the principle I'd reach for is..."* Honest reasoning out loud beats invented detail. The assessor isn't looking for omniscience; they're looking for someone who can think about an unfamiliar question with the right frame.

Q: *I'm worried about running out of things to say before 60 minutes is up.*

A: That almost never happens. The assessor will pace the discussion; if you've answered fully, they'll move on. If they're moving fast, that's a good sign. The Discussion Map is a guide, not a fixed running order.

Q: *What if I disagree with a premise in the assessor's question?*

A: Say so, politely. *"I'd push back gently on that framing – in my experience..."* Distinction-grade thinking includes being willing to challenge a starting premise when you have grounds. Just bring the evidence with you.

Q: *What if I get emotional – nervous, frustrated, blank?*

A: Use the recovery techniques. Pause. Reach for the portfolio. Sip water. The recording shows audio only; the assessor is on your side. One bad moment doesn't define the hour – recovery does.

Q: *Can I bring written notes into the discussion?*

A: Yes. The portfolio is allowed on screen. A Discussion Map sketch on a notepad is allowed. Bullet-point reminders are allowed. *Reading from a script is not.* Brief glances at notes between questions are professional, not penalised.

Q: *What if my video conferencing drops out mid-discussion?*

A: The EPAO has a protocol for this. Reconnect; the assessor will pick up where you left off. Don't try to talk through a glitchy connection – ask them to wait while you reconnect properly. Technical hiccups are common and handled.

Q: *How much can I prepare – is there a point where over-prep becomes a problem?*

A: Yes. Memorising answers verbatim is the over-prep trap – rehearsed-sounding answers lose authenticity marks. Aim to know your anchor stories cold, your Discussion Map cold, your three Why-Layer phrases cold. Everything else should sound like you talking, not like recital.

Bullet Points — the whole of Phase 2 in 30 seconds

- **The portfolio is already written.** Phase 2 was rehearsal, not creation.
- **The Portfolio Mining Pass** (Day 10) gave you your anchor stories.
- **STARR** (Day 11) is the universal answer shape. Five layers. The second R is where Distinction lives.
- **Four content areas, four mini-devices.** The Why Stack (D12) • The Verification Story (D13) • The Audience Switch (D14) • The Behaviour Story (D15).
- **The Why Layer** (Day 16) is the Pass → Distinction upgrade. Three additions to your Reflection.
- **The Discussion Map** (Day 17) is your 60-minute mental layout. Five segments, Distinction sentences pre-loaded.
- **Recovery techniques:** pause, reach for the portfolio, reframe, honest unknown, come back later. No bluffing.
- **You're ready.**

TEST DRIVE

Final ticks. By now, all of these should be true.

- ☐ You can recite the five layers of STARR from memory.
- ☐ You have 4-6 anchor stories — one per content area, minimum.
- ☐ You have at least one Why-Layer sentence ready for D1, D2, and D3.
- ☐ You can deliver a 90-second portfolio opener from memory.
- ☐ You've run at least one full 60-minute mock with self-review.
- ☐ You have your day-of room, water, phone, portfolio, notepad sorted.

The writing was done before you started.

The rehearsal is done now.

The conversation is the easy bit.

that's the programme. go and have the conversation.